

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

technique for handling his bank deposits. He used three checking accounts. One month he would put money into the first account, the following month into the second, and the third month into the third. He assumed that the bank would have his first checking account balanced by the time the fourth month came around. So he would just accept their balance as being accurate, deposit his paycheck, and start writing more checks.

You can guess what happened. One time the first account didn't get balanced by the bank. There was a large check that didn't clear, so the account showed more money in the bank than he actually had. That month he wrote about a dozen bad checks and one merchant had him arrested. In some states, if you write an insufficient check for \$2 or more, a merchant can swear out a warrant. One did, and the police locked up this pastor. A member of his congregation had to come and bail him out, which was very embarrassing, to say the least. His method worked for a while, but it ultimately failed.

Even if a wife maintains the checking account, the budget must be done together. I recommend two things in keeping a checking account. One, have only one bookkeeper. If the wife keeps the checking account, she keeps the checkbook. If the husband needs a check, he should borrow the checkbook, write the check, and return it that day. It is very difficult to keep your account balanced when more than one person has frequent access to the checkbook. Second, I recommend that you use a checkbook that has a carbon copy system. The most common problem in bookkeeping is writing the wrong amount in the checkbook. With the carbon copy checkbook, you always have an accurate record. When balancing the checkbook, one person should do it. The wife can ask for the husband's help or vice versa. But once you have a workable system, stick with it. As an old cliché says, "Too many hands in the pot will spoil the stew." The same goes with a bank statement.

QUESTION 2. Does a couple really need a budget?

Does a couple really need a budget when they're first married?